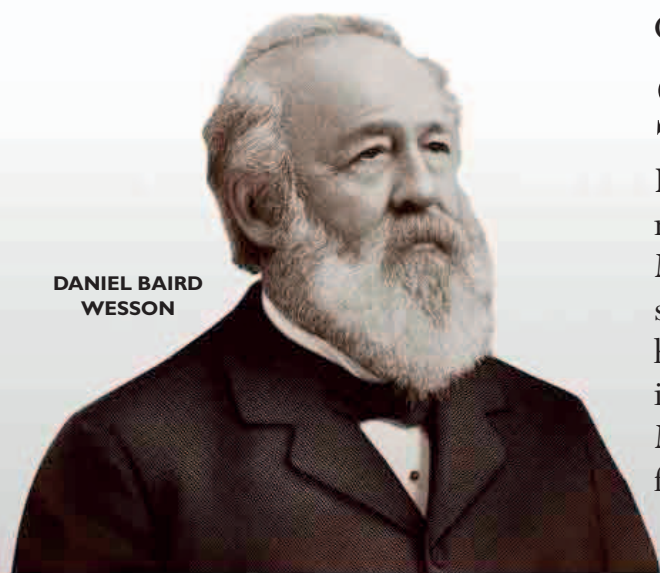


DANIEL BAIRD
WESSON

GREAT GUNSMITHS

SMITH AND WESSON

Horace Smith and Daniel Baird Wesson were two of history's most influential gunmakers. Their first major achievement was the Model 1, a revolver that was simple to use because it did away with separate powder, ball, and percussion cap—to load it, all that the user had to do was to drop self-contained metal cartridges (see pp.112–13) into the cylinder. This remarkable revolver, and the larger-caliber Model 2, established Smith and Wesson as one of the best-known firearms manufacturers in the United States.

Gunmakers Horace Smith and D. B. Wesson first collaborated in the early 1850s, when they worked on the production of a repeating pistol operated by lever action (see p.114) and based on an earlier design by Hunt and Jennings. The weapon had impressive fire power, earning it the name “Volcanic,” but it proved unreliable. Its cartridges sometimes got stuck in the barrel and occasionally several of the volatile cartridges went off at once. Wesson devised an improved, self-contained metal cartridge for the gun, but the weapon still lacked a way of extracting the cartridge cases with ease and sales did not improve.

When the main investor pulled out, the business was bought by Oliver Winchester, who went on to develop his successful repeating rifle. Smith left the business, as eventually did Wesson.

COMBINING INNOVATIONS

By 1856, Samuel Colt's patent on the revolver, which he took out in 1835, was about to run out and Wesson wanted to design a revolver that fired the self-contained metal cartridge. Horace Smith was impressed with Wesson's plans and teamed up with him once again. The metal cartridge needed a bored-through

revolver cylinder, allowing cartridges to be loaded from the rear. The bored-through cylinder had already been patented by a gunsmith named Rollin White, so Smith and Wesson made a deal with him. They licensed his patent, agreeing to pay White a royalty on each pistol they sold. White retained the patent and remained responsible for defending his patent rights should any other manufacturer try to produce a revolver with a similar cylinder. The Smith and Wesson Model 1, a seven-shot revolver incorporating White's cylinder and firing Wesson's self-contained .22in rim-fire cartridge, was launched in 1857. It became popular, heralding the end of percussion arms. Soon other manufacturers

“The Pistol... proves to be one of the most powerful weapons I ever saw.”

FROM A LETTER WRITTEN IN 1862 BY C. F. ACHENBACK,
A GUN OWNER, TO SMITH AND WESSON **ON THE MODEL 1**

▼ SMITH AND WESSON FACTORY

A worker operates a rifling machine while others assemble revolver barrels and cylinders at the Smith and Wesson factory in Springfield, Massachusetts, in 1880.

